

Working with Ella — A Practical Guide for Michael

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For: Michael Gulden, Active Oahu Tours **Context:** Ella Georgeson starts this week as content writer. This guide translates how you're both wired so you can work together effectively — no jargon, just practical do's and don'ts.

Quick Summary: How You're Each Wired

Michael — You see things clearly and quickly. Your best insights come in flashes (you just *know*). But you don't have a built-in energy battery — you work in focused bursts and then need real recovery. You learn by trying, failing, and iterating. People naturally look to you for answers, which is powerful but exhausting. Your core need: boundaries and alone time to recharge.

Ella — She has a deep, renewable energy tank. She's built to build — she can work for hours and keep going. But she doesn't work from a blank page well; she needs something to respond to. Her feelings about decisions shift over hours (morning vs. evening opinions can differ), and she genuinely needs time for her real answer to surface. She has natural talents she barely recognizes in herself.

1. Energy: Don't Try to Match Her Pace (CRITICAL)

Ella can sustain work for hours. You can't — and shouldn't try.

DO: - Give Ella long-form content tasks that need sustained focus and time - Use yourself for strategic direction, review, and high-leverage guidance - Set clear deadlines for Ella and let her run - Check in at milestones, not mid-flow - Schedule your focused review in one burst (e.g., Thursday afternoon)

DON'T: - Try to match Ella's work pace hour-for-hour - Feel guilty that she's working more hours than you — she's built for it, you're not - Let "she's still working" pressure you into skipping recovery time

The dynamic: Think of Ella as having a marathon runner's engine and you having a sprinter's engine. Both are valuable. Neither is broken. The mistake is entering a marathon as a sprinter.

2. Decisions: Give Her Time (MAJOR)

You make instant gut decisions. Ella's decisions need to settle through her feelings over hours — sometimes a full day. What she says in the moment isn't her final answer.

DO: - "Sleep on it and let me know tomorrow morning" - "No rush — what do you think by end of week?" - Send options, topics, or drafts in advance so she can sit with them - If you need input on content direction, send it the day before the discussion

DON'T: - Ask "which of these should we do?" and expect an answer in the same conversation - Pressure her for immediate yes/no on anything meaningful - Interpret "I'm not sure" in the moment as her real position - Assume excitement in a call = lasting commitment (or that hesitation = rejection)

The dynamic: Your decisions come from the gut — fast and final. Hers come from an emotional tide that rises and falls. The tide reveals the real answer, not the first wave.

3. Assignments: Give Her Seeds, Not a Blank Page

Ella's engine kicks in when she has something to *respond* to. A blank page with "write something about kayaking" forces her into a mode she's not wired for, and that creates frustration and procrastination.

DO — For every assignment, provide three things: 1. **A working title** — even a rough one ("Why Winter Is the Best Time to Kayak Oahu" — you can change it later) 2. **3-5 bullet points** of what to cover ("mention the whale migration, water clarity, smaller crowds, and temperature") 3. **One example** of good similar content (a competitor's page, a past blog post you liked, even a paragraph you wrote once)

DON'T: - "Write something about [topic]" with nothing else - Expect her to generate topics from scratch regularly - Give purely verbal assignments — she needs written direction

Why this works: Ella's natural mode is response. Give her a rough shape to react to, and her energy engages. The seed can be sloppy — her gift is building and improving on it, not originating from nothing.

Practical template: > *Topic:* [working title] > *Cover:* [3-5 bullet points] > *Reference:* [link or description of similar content] > *Deadline:* [date] > *Length:* [word count range]

4. Feedback: Lead With What She's Good At (IMPORTANT)

Ella has natural gifts that come so easily to her, she genuinely doesn't see them as special. She won't self-identify her strengths accurately. She needs *you* to call them out specifically.

DO — Every piece of feedback should include at least one specific strength observation *before* any revision notes: - “Your description of the sandbar was vivid — you have a real gift for sensory detail.” - “That transition from history to practical tips was smooth — that’s genuinely hard to do.” - “The way you structured this with the question at the top grabbed me — strong instinct for hooks.”

DON’T: - Ask “what do you think your strengths are?” as your main feedback approach - Give only correction notes with no positive callouts - Assume she knows what’s working in her writing

Why this matters: Her talents operate below her conscious awareness. When you name them, you help her see them — and she can intentionally develop them rather than stumble into them by accident. This isn’t about being nice. It’s how her brain works.

5. When You Change Direction: Frame It as Building, Not Replacing

You learn by iterating — try something, see what works, scrap it, try again. This is normal and valuable. But Ella may interpret scrapped work as personal rejection because she values stability in working relationships.

DO: - Say explicitly: “This is iteration, not rejection. Your draft was good — I’m just trying a different angle.” - Frame changes as building on work: “Let’s take what you wrote and pivot the angle toward [X].” - Explain the *why* behind a direction change: “I realized the audience for this is actually [Y], so we need to adjust.”

DON’T: - “Start over” with no context or acknowledgment - Scrap her work silently and assign something new without connecting the dots - Let iteration feel like whiplash — bridge the gap between versions

The dynamic: Your iteration style is a strength — it’s how you find the right approach. Just give Ella the narrative that connects Version A to Version B so she doesn’t internalize the change as failure.

6. Boundaries: Protect Your Alone Time (HIDDEN CRITICAL)

You have a deep, wiring-level need for clear boundaries between work and rest. Without them, you burn out and feel resentful — and that resentment is a warning sign, not a character flaw.

DO: - Set explicit availability: “I’m available for questions 9–11am and 2–4pm. Outside that, Slack me and I’ll reply next window.” - Use async communication (Slack, email) as the default. Real-time calls should be scheduled. - Protect your recharge time aggressively — it’s maintenance, not laziness. - If you feel yourself getting resentful about “having to do everything,” that’s the signal: you’re over-functioning and need to step back.

DON’T: - Let work bleed into evenings and weekends as the norm - Feel obligated to be “always on” just because Ella has more energy endurance - Ignore the resentment feeling — it’s your internal alarm

system

Why this matters for Ella too: When you're clear about your boundaries, Ella knows what to expect. Uncertainty about when you're available creates anxiety in her — she doesn't have a fixed internal compass for direction, so she relies on external clarity from you.

7. What Ella Absorbs From You (Without Either of You Realizing It)

Ella has a permeable quality — she picks up and amplifies what's happening in you. This means your state directly affects her performance.

Direction & Purpose: If you're clear about the company vision and where things are headed, Ella aligns naturally and works with confidence. If you're uncertain or wavering, she'll feel unmoored. Show conviction, even about the next step.

Stress & Anxiety: She has no fixed intuition and no internal fear filter. She will absorb your business anxieties and carry them as her own, even if you never say them out loud. Manage your stress around her — vent to someone else, not Ella.

Expectations: She absorbs others' expectations and tends to over-commit trying to prove herself. Explicitly release her from proving anything: "Your work speaks for itself. You don't need to prove yourself here."

Mental Pressure: If you're anxious about the business, she'll feel that mental pressure as her own and may spin without knowing why. Keep your internal pressure contained.

Practical takeaway: You set the emotional weather. If you're grounded and clear, she thrives. If you're anxious and unsettled, she absorbs it and her work reflects it.

8. Communication Rules

1. **Written over verbal:** Give direction in writing. Verbal instructions get lost because she absorbs your state more than your words.
 2. **Async first:** Slack and email are your default channels. Schedule calls; don't surprise-call.
 3. **Recognition before correction:** Always lead with what worked. This isn't coddling — it's how she registers feedback.
 4. **Emotional wave buffer:** If she seems excited about a project on Tuesday and flat about the same project on Wednesday, that's her emotional wave moving, not flakiness. Wait for it to settle before drawing conclusions.
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9. Suggested Weekly Rhythm

Day	Michael	Ella
Monday AM	Send the week's content briefs (topics + seeds + references)	Receive briefs, start reviewing
Monday-Tuesday	—	Sit with topics, ride emotional wave, let ideas percolate
Wednesday	—	Writing day (Sacral energy in flow)
Thursday	—	Submit drafts
Thursday PM	Review all drafts in one focused burst	—
Friday	—	Revise based on feedback; wrap up

This rhythm gives Ella the emotional runway she needs before creating, gives you focused review time instead of scattered checking, and respects both of your energy patterns.

10. When Things Go Wrong: Warning Signs

Michael's warning sign: Feeling resentful or bitter — “I have to do everything around here.” This means you're over-functioning, not taking recovery time, or pushing guidance when it's not being received. **Action:** Step back. Rest. Set a boundary. Wait for the invitation before re-engaging.

Ella's warning sign: Procrastination, feeling stuck, or visible frustration. This almost always means she's being asked to initiate from nothing rather than respond to something. **Action:** Give her a seed. A rough draft. A question. A competitor example. Something to react to.

11. Quick Reference: Do / Don't

DO

- Give her something to respond to (never a blank page)
- Allow 24 hours for real decisions
- Call out her specific strengths in every feedback session
- Frame iteration as “building on” not “replacing”
- Set and communicate clear availability hours
- Use written direction over verbal
- Protect your recharge time
- Lead with the company direction clearly and consistently
- Release her from needing to prove herself

DON'T

- Try to match her work pace
 - Pressure for immediate decisions
 - Say “write something about [topic]” with no further direction
 - Scrap work without explanation
 - Assume she knows what she’s good at
 - Let work bleed into personal time
 - Express business anxiety to her (vent elsewhere)
 - Surprise-call or interrupt her flow
 - Take her emotional shifts personally
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The Bottom Line

You’re a guide who sees clearly and works in bursts. She’s a builder with sustained energy who needs something to respond to. Your job is to set direction, provide seeds, call out her gifts, and protect your boundaries. Her job is to take those seeds and build. When this works, you get the best of both — your strategic vision plus her creative endurance — without burning either of you out.

She starts this week. Give her seeds. Give her time. Point out what she does well. And take your recovery time seriously. You’ve got this.